9. View from the Mountain Top

It takes time, on emerging briefly from the bubble of international sport, to get used to the light and shade of life. You think you can gauge the public mood by looking at online trends and talking to friends, but it is not until you are confronted by the impact of your achievements on a human level that you appreciate their deeper meaning.

The English are generally reticent about approaching recognizable figures, but I lost count of the number of people who came up to stress how happy we had made them feel by winning the Ashes in Australia. So many confessed, like guilty schoolchildren, that they had stayed awake all night during the previous six weeks and snatched surreptitious naps in the office.

My depressurization process began in a pressurized first-class cabin, to which Alice and I were upgraded on the way home. That twenty-four-hour journey, free from phones, email and Wi-Fi, allowed me to reflect and reset. I had never felt such personal satisfaction. That deep ache of insecurity had gone – for the moment, at least. I knew I could not have done any more.

As a team, we were in rarefied air, close to the summit of our Everest. We still had a home series against India to negotiate, the equivalent of the deadly Hilary Step, before we could call ourselves the best team in the world, but we were relentless. We reached the peak at Edgbaston on 13 August 2011, precisely 918 days after that honesty meeting in Kingston, Jamaica.

India's spirit, weakened by heavy losses in the first two Tests, was finally broken on the third day of the game. This may sound silly, but there are